

Ergonomically, all the laptops are no-frills products. The IBM misses out on a touchpad, but offers its patented track point. But it makes up for it by offering a good, solid keyboard.

Except for Zenith, all notebooks ran Windows XP Home Edition. IBM was the only one to supply a recovery CD, along with other useful IBM utilities that help you recover the factory conditions in case your system crashes. Most came with average quality carry cases.

Only the ACi Emerald Pro and Emerald C come with a three-year warranty, the rest offer a one-year warranty. Wipro offers an on-site warranty—the rest offer a carry-in warranty. The turn-around-time (the time it takes for you to get a new laptop, or get your laptop back after repairs) typically ranges from 12 to 48 hours across various vendors.

Performance

ACi's Emerald Pro performed well; hot on its heels was Zenith's Performer. While both were on par in most tests, the Emerald Pro sported a better battery time—still not enough to watch an entire movie on a single charge. IBM and Wipro couldn't keep up with their feeble Celeron processors.

ACi's Emerald C, the lone Centrino notebook, fared well, but was edged out in the end. Astonishingly, the Mercury notebook offered better battery life than the Centrino-based Emerald C. ACi's Ethos V returned poor scores.



ACi Emerald Pro



Wipro Little Genius 1000D

Despite the weakest processor of the lot, it managed to pass most of our stress tests, proving that it's worth its amazingly low price tag.

Conclusion

The budget category needs the maximum value from a minimal investment. The feature sets and usability of all the laptops were almost identical, so it was up to the performance scores to decide the winner. ACi's Emerald Pro emerged winner; however, we should mention that the margin over the competition was nothing special. The Wipro Little Genius 1000D turned in good performance scores; this, coupled with good pricing and the great offer of an on-site warranty pushed it ahead of the Zenith performer to win the Best Buy Silver award. Zenith's Performer and Wipro's Little Genius 4000D are also commendable buys, and perform better than the Wipro Little Genius 1000D.

If it wasn't for the below-par performance, ACi's Ethos V would be the perfect example of a budget laptop.

If you have a low budget and need to deploy laptops for your team, nothing matches the cheap Ethos V.

How We Tested And How We Decided The Award Winners

We assessed laptops on five main parameters—features, performance, usability, price and warranty, and support. Weightages varied, depending on the importance of a parameter to a particular category. Windows XP Professional SP1 was the standard operating system. We also loaded all the latest drivers for optimum performance.

Features

We noted features such as the type of RAM, hard disk capacity, the optical drive provided, types of ports, etc. As per their importance, weightages were attached and thereby scores derived.

Usability

Usability was evaluated on the basis of how simple or difficult it was to handle the device in our everyday lives—of primary importance here were weight, dimensions, and ergonomically inclined factors such as keyboard feel, touchpad sensitivity, etc. As a measure of heat dissipation, we logged temperatures, shown by a thermistor-based device, at various points on the notebook.

Package contents

We checked whether the vendors provided OSeS, recovery CD with the laptop. We also noted extra software and

accessories—power adapter, carry case, etc., bundled along.

Performance

We ran a number of tests to evaluate each individual sub-system. The following benchmarking suites were used:
SiSoft Sandra 2004 Professional: This synthetic benchmarking suite evaluated CPU, memory and hard disk performances. The scores for each individual sub-system were noted down.
PCMark 2004: PCMark 2004 is a system-wide benchmark that tests the complete system as well as individual components such as processor, and graphics sub-system and returns aggregated scores.
Ziff Davis Business Winstone 2004: This benchmark tests using applications that are used on a daily basis, evaluates complete system performance, and returns a unified score. Higher the score, the better is the system performance.
Video encoding: Here, we encoded a 50 MB .vob file using Dr DivX to convert it into the AVI format. The time taken do so was noted.
Call of Duty: The game was run at resolutions of 800 x 600 and 1,024 x 768, and the average fps was noted down.

DisplayMate Video Edition: The LCD display was evaluated using tools such as Point Shape and Visibility, and Streaking and Ghosting slides. Protractor was used to measure the maximum viewing angle from which you can read text on a white background.

WiFi test: NetCPS—a utility that pumps data to test TCP/IP connections was used to evaluate WiFi data throughput. We also copied 20 MB of assorted data and streamed a movie file too—all via WiFi.

Digit Battery Meter: We ran a .vob file till the battery drained. A software timer developed inhouse kept time.

Warranty and Support: Apart from the support, warranty period, we also took into account the number of service centres and the average turnaround time.

How The Awards Are Given

The scores from features, performance, usability, warranty and support, and price, are given weightages relevant to the specific category. An overall score out of 100 is calculated.

The product that scores the highest here is adjudged the winner of the **Digit Best Buy Gold** award for its category. The second highest scorer gets the **Digit Best Buy Silver** award.